

One-Party Legislatures? Partisan Dominance in Nigeria's State Houses of Assembly*

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Abstract

Party-system fragmentation is conventionally interpreted as evidence of competition, and competition as the engine of accountability. This paper identifies a condition under which that inference fails. Drawing on an original dataset of 2,975 legislators across all 36 Nigerian states and three electoral cycles (2015, 2019, 2023), I document a puzzle: between 2015 and 2023 the effective number of parties in the state assemblies rose and zero-opposition chambers all but disappeared, yet the governor's party retained supermajority control of the floor. I argue that opposition fragmentation operated as a mechanism of authoritarian resilience. New parties entered divided, each lacking the patronage infrastructure to cohere into a legislative bloc, so splitting the anti-incumbent vote produced the appearance of pluralism without the substance of accountability. A governor party-switch quasi-experiment, in which the incoming party is exogenous to the assembly's composition, and a cross-carpeting analysis of returning legislators trace the mechanism. The Nigerian case extends the subnational authoritarianism framework and specifies when counting parties conceals executive capture.

Keywords: Nigeria, state legislatures, party dominance, subnational authoritarianism, effective number of parties, democratic consolidation

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1 Introduction

In the 2019–2023 legislative term, ten of Nigeria’s thirty-six State Houses of Assembly contained not a single opposition member. In Cross River, Ebonyi, and Enugu, every seat belonged to the governor’s party. The same held in Borno, Jigawa, and Kebbi. Across all thirty-six assemblies, the governor’s party held an average of 79 percent of seats. One-party assemblies are replicated thirty-six times under the formal architecture of a federal democracy.

This result poses a puzzle for a standard expectation in the democratization literature. More parties winning seats, and a rising effective number of parties, is conventionally understood as more competition, and more competition is interpreted as more accountability. The cross-national record is less settled. Fragmentation blurs which incumbents voters can hold responsible (Powell and Whitten, 1993), tracks higher corruption under some electoral rules (Chang and Golden, 2007; Schleiter and Voznaya, 2018), and leaves oppositions larger but more divided (Best, 2013); where electoral reforms raised the number of parties directly, democratic quality moved little (Valentim and Dinas, 2024). Nigeria’s state assemblies show fragmentation sitting alongside, and sustaining, the governor’s dominance. Between 2015 and 2023 the effective number of parties in the assemblies rose and the count of zero-opposition chambers collapsed, yet the governor’s party kept its grip on the floor and on the two-thirds threshold that governs impeachment and confirmation. Fragmentation went up; accountability did not. This paper answers when, and why, rising fragmentation fails to translate into legislative competition.

I argue that opposition fragmentation can operate as a mechanism of authoritarian resilience. New parties entered the assemblies in 2023 in their regional strongholds, but they entered separately, and each individually lacked the patronage infrastructure to sustain a cohesive legislative bloc against the governor. Splitting the anti-incumbent vote across several such parties raises the effective number of parties and populates once-empty opposition benches while leaving the governor’s party as the largest and only disciplined bloc. The result is the appearance of pluralism, a higher effective

number of parties and fewer one-party chambers, without its substance, a legislature able to check the executive. This paper reframes fragmentation from a symptom of loosening control into one of its instruments, and it identifies the condition under which the familiar multipartism-implies-competition inference fails.

The 2015 election produced the first peaceful turnover of presidential power in Nigeria's Fourth Republic, ending sixteen years of the People's Democratic Party (PDP) federal incumbency and bringing the All Progressives Congress (APC) to power under President Muhammadu Buhari. Scholars and the press treated the moment as evidence that Nigerian democracy had matured (Owen and Usman, 2015; LeVan, 2019). If that maturation extended to the state level, the 2015 cycle should mark the start of greater partisan competition in the 36 state assemblies. The data show otherwise: across 2015, 2019, and 2023, the governor's party held an average of 71 to 83 percent of seats, and between 21 and 30 of the 36 assemblies remained under supermajority control. New parties won seats in their regional strongholds in 2023, and zero-opposition assemblies fell from ten to one, but the governor's hold on the legislature did not loosen.

I document and explain this puzzle using an original dataset of 2,975 state assembly legislators across three electoral cycles (2015, 2019, 2023).¹ Existing scholarship on subnational authoritarianism in Nigeria (Baba, 2015; Madueke, 2025; Cruz and Johnson-Kanu, 2026) and party system institutionalization (Angerbrandt, 2020) theorizes about executive dominance but lacks the systematic seat-level data to measure it. I construct Effective Number of Parties (ENP) measures for all 108 state-terms and estimate OLS models in which the 2023 year dummy is the only consistent predictor of assembly composition. This paper's causal leverage relies on a governor party-switch quasi-experiment. In the seven between-term cases where the governing party changed, the incoming governor inherited an assembly built by the previous party's machinery, and because legislators choose their party and are nominated before the gubernatorial outcome is known, the new governor's party identity is exogenous to

¹The three electoral cycles refer to the federal election cycles in Nigeria, in which the presidential, gubernatorial, and state assembly elections are all held within the same election period.

the assembly's existing partisan composition. The assembly's response, a rise in the effective number of parties and a fall in the governor-party seat share, is therefore attributable to the party turnover and not to reverse causation. A cross-carpeting analysis of returning legislators triangulates the same claim at the individual level.

The paper contributes to the literature on three fronts. First, it develops the fragmentation-as-resilience argument and shows the condition under which more parties do not mean more competition, a modification to the multipartism-implies-accountability expectation that carries beyond Nigeria to any subnational authoritarian setting where opposition parties lack the resources to cohere. Second, it extends the subnational authoritarianism framework (Gibson, 2012; Giraudy, 2015) to African legislatures, demonstrating that Nigeria's 2015 turnover at the national level coexisted with persistent one-party gubernatorial control at the state level, and it supplies the systematic seat-level data that this scholarship (Baba, 2015) has lacked. Third, it identifies cross-carpeting as a micro-level mechanism of dominance consolidation, connecting to the comparative literature on legislative party switching (Heller and Mershon, 2009; Mershon and Shvetsova, 2013; Agboga, 2024). The findings also speak to how subnational democratic erosion is measured: fragmentation indices taken one way at the national level can mask, executive capture at the state level. I discuss on the implications for parliamentary-strengthening programs in Nigeria, which confront an incentive structure in which two-thirds of members turn over each cycle and the governor's party holds the majority. As the 2027 national and state elections approach, the opposition has splintered again at the national level, and I conclude this paper by asking what the state-assembly evidence presented here predicts for that contest.

2 Executive Dominance in Subnational Legislatures

The democratization literature assumes that competitive elections at the national level produce spillover effects at the subnational level: if incumbents can lose nationally, this should embolden opposition challengers everywhere. The subnational author-

itarianism literature challenges this assumption. In Argentina, subnational incumbents use party structures, patronage, and institutional prerogatives to insulate their domains from national-level competition (Gibson, 2005, 2012). Similar dynamics persist in post-transition Mexico (Giraudy, 2010, 2015), the Southern United States (Key, 1949; Mickey, 2015), and Russia (Gel'man, 2010). A fiscal mechanism reinforces the dynamic: federal transfers create “rentier” conditions that allow subnational incumbents to suppress competition (Gervasoni, 2010). This has parallels to Nigeria’s FAAC (Federation Account Allocation Committee) revenue-sharing system, which sends a monthly share of national oil and tax revenue to each state government. Comparative work confirms that subnational regime variation is a feature of all large federal democracies (Behrend and Whitehead, 2016; Giraudy et al., 2019).

Nigeria represents a critical case for extending this framework to Africa. If a peaceful party turnover in the continent’s most populous country fails to produce greater competition at the subnational level, the subnational authoritarianism dynamic operates in Africa as well. Yet legislative studies in Africa focus almost exclusively on national parliaments (Barkan, 2009; Opalo, 2019). The most sustained engagement with subnational legislatures covers four African countries, with qualitative evidence from three Nigerian states (LeVan et al., 2015; Baba, 2015). Work on legislative oversight under Nigeria’s presidential system (Fashagba, 2009) and on legislative turnover rates (Akinola and Mosunmola, 2023) provides useful context but not systematic data on partisan composition. Rich literature on US state legislatures (Squire and Hamm, 2005; Squire, 2007), Mexican state assemblies (Beer, 2003), and Brazilian state legislatures (Samuels, 2003) have no equivalent for any African country. Nigeria’s 36 simultaneously operating assemblies, observed across three electoral cycles, offer a setting for subnational analysis that no other African case provides.

The limited literature on Nigerian state legislatures consistently characterizes them as executive-dominated. Nigeria’s hypercentralized federalism grants governors fiscal and political leverage (Suberu, 1993); governors function as “mini-presidents” who control legislative agendas through party discipline, patronage, and impeachment

threats (Baba, 2015). Some scholars characterize this configuration as a “federated autocracy” (Madueke, 2025). Even at the national level, executive dominance over the legislature is well-documented (Fashagba et al., 2019; Demarest and Langer, 2023).

Governors manufacture legislative supermajorities through several channels: control over candidate selection in party primaries, patronage flows from FAAC allocations and state Internally Generated Revenue (IGR), first-past-the-post (FPTP) electoral rules in small assemblies (24–40 seats) that mechanically amplify seat majorities (Duverger, 1954); and cross-carpeting, the practice of legislators defecting between parties (Awofeso and Irabor, 2016; PLAC, 2023). A companion paper traces this dominance to its institutional fulcrum, the speakership, and finds that 94 percent of Speakers come from the governor’s party and that every between-term change in the governing party produces a change in the Speaker (Johnson-Kanu, 2026). Cross-carpeting is widespread across African legislatures (Goeke and Hartmann, 2011), well-documented in the Nigerian Senate (Fashagba, 2014), and increasingly studied for its effects on voter behavior (Agboga, 2023, 2024). The comparative literature on legislative party switching demonstrates that defection toward the ruling party is a common mechanism of one-party consolidation across diverse settings (Heller and Mershon, 2009; Mershon and Shvetsova, 2013; Yoshinaka, 2015).

State-level party systems in Nigeria are structured around regional strongmen instead of programmatic platforms (Angerbrandt, 2020). African party systems are weakly institutionalized (Kuenzi and Lambright, 2001; Manning, 2005), and incumbent parties tend to be more nationalized than opposition parties (Wahman, 2017). The party nationalization literature predicts that subnational party systems will be most congruent with national ones where fiscal centralization is greatest.² Nigeria’s hypercentralized fiscal federalism should therefore produce relatively nationalized state-level party systems, a prediction the data confirm.

These accounts leave open how party-system fragmentation relates to accountabil-

²On party nationalization see Jones and Mainwaring (2003); on the centralization link Chhibber and Kollman (2004); on congruence across federations Thorlakson (2007); and on national forces in subnational elections Schakel (2013) and Rogers (2016).

ity at the subnational level. The default interpretation in the democratization literature treats a rising effective number of parties as evidence of intensifying competition, and competition as the engine of accountability: where more parties contest and win seats, incumbents face credible challengers and legislatures gain the capacity to check the executive. That argument holds when the entering parties can cohere into a durable opposition bloc. It need not hold where they cannot. In a subnational authoritarian setting, the incumbent's advantage rests less on vote share than on control of patronage: candidate selection, committee assignments, and the fiscal flows that reward loyalty (Gibson, 2012; Gervasoni, 2010). An opposition that arrives divided across several parties, each individually short of that infrastructure, cannot convert its seats into a disciplined counterweight. The governor's party remains the only bloc able to hold the floor together.

I argue that under these conditions opposition fragmentation operates as a mechanism of authoritarian resilience rather than of its erosion. Splitting the anti-incumbent vote across parties that individually lack the resources to sustain legislative cohesion raises the effective number of parties and fills once-empty opposition benches, producing the appearance of pluralism, while leaving the governor's party in command of the floor and of the two-thirds threshold that impeachment and confirmation require. Fragmentation, on this account, is not the visible edge of a loosening grip but one of the forms that a secure grip can take. This claim modifies the competition-accountability link: it specifies the condition, an opposition too resource-poor to cohere, under which the multipartism-implies-competition interpretation fails, and it is that condition, not Nigerian exceptionalism, that lets the case travel to other subnational authoritarian settings. This argument also carries a measurement implication: fragmentation indices that register pluralism at one level of aggregation can conceal executive capture at another, so subnational democratic erosion is not reliably detected by counting parties.

Three testable predictions follow from the above discussion, each an observable implication of the resilience argument. First, the governor's party should hold super-

majority control ($\geq 67\%$ of seats) in the majority of state assemblies across all three terms, reflecting the structural dominance of the executive over the legislature (H1). Second, when a governorship changes party between terms, the assembly should not immediately realign: the new governor inherits a legislature populated by the previous governor's party machine, producing a temporary reduction in the new governor's seat share (H2). Realignment is slow because the assembly seats are fixed for four years and the governor has only two tools for repopulating them, neither of which works overnight. The governor's primary tool is control over the next round of candidate primaries, which takes effect only at the following election. The governor can also induce cross-carpeting among sitting legislators, which proceeds case by case and depends on the incoming governor's ability to extend patronage to legislators recruited by his predecessor. Third, cross-carpeting among returning legislators should flow asymmetrically toward the party that controls the governorship (and the presidency), reinforcing one-party dominance between elections through elite bandwagoning (H3).

3 Nigeria's State Houses of Assembly

Section 90 of the 1999 Constitution establishes a House of Assembly in each of Nigeria's 36 states, restoring elected state legislatures for the first time since the December 1983 military takeover. The 36-state structure has been continuous since 1996, when the most recent six states were created; the 1999 democratic transition placed an assembly in each. The 2023 elections were the seventh state-assembly cycle of the Fourth Republic³, with the same 36 assemblies operating throughout ⁴.

Each state's assembly is unicameral, with between 24 and 40 members elected from single-member constituencies under FPTP rules. Members serve four-year terms (Section 105) and must be at least 30 years of age, sponsored by a registered political party, and educated to at least the School Certificate level (Section 106). Nationwide there are

³Republics are democratic periods in the country's history. They include: First Republic (October 1, 1963 – January 15, 1966), Second Republic (October 1, 1979 – December 31, 1983), Third Republic (January 2, 1993 – November 17, 1993), and the current Fourth Republic (May 29, 1999 – Present)

⁴election years: 1999, 2003, 2007, 2011, 2015, 2019, 2023, 2027

991 state-assembly constituencies, with 993 in the 2023–2027 cycle after the National Assembly restored two Benue State seats by court order. State assembly elections occur concurrently with gubernatorial elections, typically on the same day, creating coattail effects between the gubernatorial and legislative races (Samuels, 2000).

The 991 constituencies are population-based and are not coterminous with the 774 local government areas (LGAs). Most LGAs contain more than one assembly constituency, and a few constituencies span multiple LGAs. The constituencies in their current configuration predate the Fourth Republic, having been delimited in the 1990s using 1991 census data; despite the 2006 national census, no comprehensive re-delimitation has followed. State assemblies are therefore distinct from local government councils both administratively and territorially. The state houses of assembly handle state-level matters: legislation on the Concurrent Legislative List (Section 4 and Part II of the Second Schedule), the state budget, oversight of the executive, confirmation of the governor's appointments under Section 192(2), and impeachment under Section 188.

The assemblies exercise formal powers in five areas. Lawmaking covers all matters not assigned exclusively to the federal government. Confirmation under Section 192(2) requires assembly approval for state Commissioners, the State Chief Judge, and members of state boards. Oversight under Sections 120–128 includes summoning officials, conducting investigations, and approving the state budget. Representation directs members to advocate for constituency interests in legislation and constituency projects. Quasi-judicial powers under Section 188 grant the assembly authority to impeach the governor or deputy governor by a two-thirds majority vote, a power that requires supermajority control to exercise or to block. The principal officers of each assembly are the Speaker, Deputy Speaker, Majority Leader, and Minority Leader. The Speaker controls committee assignments, the legislative calendar, and floor proceedings.

The three electoral cycles covered in this paper span a period of partisan realignment in Nigerian politics. The APC, formed in 2013 from a merger of 3 opposition

parties⁵, defeated the PDP in both the presidential and a majority of gubernatorial races. At the state assembly level, the APC won 576 of 991 seats (58.1%), while the PDP retained 358 (36.1%). Smaller parties, principally the All Progressives Grand Alliance (APGA) with 40 seats, accounted for the remainder. This was a competitive two-party landscape in aggregate, though individual states varied.

The APC's national seat total fell to 533 (53.8%) and the PDP's rose to 391 (39.5%) between 2015 and 2019. The aggregate movement appeared to indicate increasing competition. Cross-carpeting between elections complicates the picture: governors switched parties during the inter-election period, taking their legislative allies with them. In 2023, the presidential race featured a three-way contest between the APC's Bola Tinubu, the PDP's Atiku Abubakar, and the Labour Party's (LP) Peter Obi. At the state assembly level, the APC maintained 564 seats (56.8%), nearly matching 2015. The PDP declined to 305 (30.6%), losing ground to new entrants: LP won 41 seats (concentrated in the South East), the New Nigeria Peoples Party (NNPP) won 29 (almost all in Kano), and smaller parties won a combined 53 seats. These new parties fragmented the opposition without consolidating it.

Seven states hold off-cycle gubernatorial elections (Edo, Ondo, Ekiti, Bayelsa, Anambra, Kogi, and Osun), meaning that their governor-legislature dynamics follow a different electoral calendar from the remaining 29 states. The state assembly elections in these seven states still occur on the standard federal cycle (2015, 2019, 2023), so all 36 states enter the analysis at the same three observation points; what differs is the timing of the gubernatorial election relative to the assembly election in that state. I retain the seven off-cycle states in the main analysis, since dropping them would shrink the panel by 20 percent without addressing a confound that the data themselves do not reveal as material. Robustness checks restricting the sample to the 29 on-cycle states reproduce the substantive findings reported below.

⁵the Action Congress of Nigeria (ACN), the Congress for Progressive Change (CPC), and the All Nigeria Peoples Party (ANPP), and factions from the All Progressives Grand Alliance (APGA) and the People's Democratic Party

4 Data and Methods

4.1 Data

I assemble original data on the 2,975 legislators who held seats in the 991 state-assembly constituencies (993 in 2023–2027) across the three federal electoral cycles. For each legislator I record name, party, gender, and constituency. Aggregating to the state-term level produces 108 observations ($36 \text{ states} \times 3 \text{ terms}$) with party seat counts, the governor’s party, and state-level controls.

I collected the legislator-level data through scripted web scraping and PDF extraction from Nigerian electoral sources: the Independent National Electoral Commission’s (INEC) Declaration of Winners, Stears Elections, eduweb.com.ng, Wikipedia constituency pages, and five Nigerian newspapers (Premium Times, The Punch, Vanguard, ThisDay, Daily Trust). Identifying returning members across terms required reconciling inconsistent name renderings, so I implemented a fuzzy name-matching procedure. Governor data cover all 108 state-terms and include name, party, term status, margin of victory (available for 2019 and 2023), and local government area of origin. State-level controls come from official Nigerian government sources: state population from the National Population Commission (NPC), geopolitical zone, oil-producing status from the Nigerian National Petroleum Corporation’s (NNPC) roster of states under the 13-percent derivation regime, assembly size from the 1999 Constitution’s Third Schedule, internally generated revenue (IGR) from the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS), and federation account allocations from Federation Account Allocation Committee (FAAC) monthly reports.

Constituency-level vote counts are not systematically available online for any of the three cycles, so the analysis relies on seat counts. The 2019 and 2023 legislator records are verified against INEC results; the 2015 records cover all 991 constituencies, with 440 corroborated by two or more independent sources and the remaining 551 drawn from a single source. Party affiliations are complete for all 2,975 legislators. Full information on sources, the fuzzy name-matching procedure, and verification appears

in the online appendix (Section A10). Robustness checks restricting the sample to the fully verified 2019–2023 records reproduce the substantive findings and. These results are available in the Online appendix.

4.2 Empirical Strategy

The primary measure of legislative fragmentation is the Effective Number of Parties (ENP) by seats, developed by Laakso and Taagepera (1979): $ENP_s = 1 / \sum p_i^2$, where p_i is the seat share of party i . An assembly where one party holds all seats has $ENP = 1.0$; a perfectly balanced two-party assembly has $ENP = 2.0$. I also employ the governor's party seat share (the proportion of seats held by the governor's party) and a supermajority indicator (equal to 1 if the governor's party holds $\geq 67\%$ of seats, the threshold for impeachment).

The independent variables include: geopolitical zone (six categories: North Central, North East, North West, South East, South South, South West); oil-producing state (binary); governor's term status (first term vs. second term or beyond); governor-president party alignment (binary, equal to 1 if the governor's party matches the president's); state IGR (logged); FAAC allocation (logged); state population (logged); and election year (2015, 2019, 2023).

The analysis proceeds in three stages: descriptive results documenting party seat distributions, ENP classifications, and zonal variation; ordinary least squares (OLS) regression models ($N=108$, standard errors clustered by state) with state fixed effects and first-difference specifications; and two mechanism-oriented analyses (a governor party-switch quasi-experiment and a cross-carpeting analysis). Robustness checks restrict the sample to verified 2019–2023 data, exclude off-cycle states, and substitute the Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI) for ENP.

5 Party Competition and Dynamics across State Assemblies

This section presents the empirical evidence for the three hypotheses. I begin with the aggregate national picture across the three terms and the state-level distribution of ENP. Section 5.1 reports the supermajority rate and the near-elimination of zero-opposition assemblies, the evidence for H1 (governor’s party supermajority). Section 5.2 reports the governor party-switch quasi-experiment that tests H2 (the assembly-lag prediction). Section 5.3 reports the cross-carpeting analysis that tests H3 (asymmetric defection toward the governor’s party), with robustness checks reported alongside the relevant estimates and detailed in the online appendix.

Figure 1 presents the national aggregate of state assembly seats by party across the three electoral cycles. The dominant feature is stable APC dominance combined with opposition fragmentation. The figure presents the seat counts as captured at the start of each term; the cross-carpeting analysis in Section 5.4 follows the same legislators across terms to recover between-term defections.

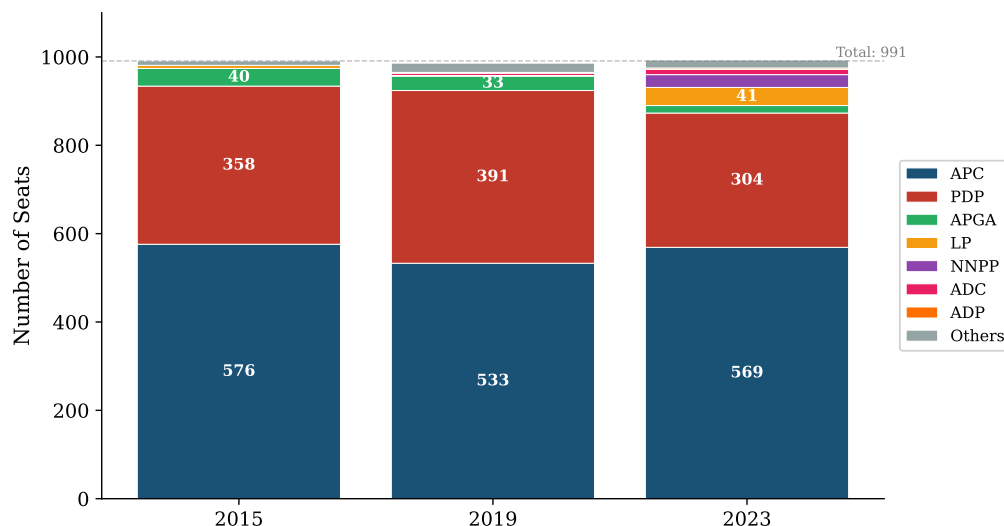


Figure 1: National distribution of state assembly seats by party, 2015–2023. The APC maintained a stable seat share across all three terms: 576 (58%), 533 (54%), and 564 (57%). The PDP declined from 358 (36%) to 305 (31%). New parties entered in 2023: the Labour Party won 41 seats (concentrated in the South East) and the NNPP won 29 (concentrated in Kano), fragmenting the opposition rather than consolidating it.

In 2015, the APC and PDP together held 94.2% of all seats. By 2019, the PDP gained 33 seats while the APC lost 43. The 2023 results introduced a new dynamic: the APC recovered to 564 seats (56.8%) while the PDP fell to 305 (30.7%), losing ground to LP (41 seats), NNPP (29), APGA (17), the African Democratic Congress (ADC, 16), the Social Democratic Party (SDP, 8), and the Young Progressives Party (YPP, 8), a combined 119 seats mostly at the PDP's expense.

Appendix Figure A1 presents the distribution of ENP across the 36 states for each term. Mean ENP rose from 1.31 in 2015 to 1.40 in 2019 and 1.71 in 2023. The 2015-to-2019 increase was not statistically significant; the 2019-to-2023 change was statistically significant across parametric and non-parametric tests.⁶ The inflection point was 2023, not 2015. Three states achieved an ENP above 2.5 in 2023 (Anambra at 2.87, Taraba at 2.69, and Abia at 2.55), the threshold I treat as competitive.

I classify each state-term into three categories: *one-party dominant* ($ENP < 1.5$), *moderate competition* ($1.5 \leq ENP < 2.5$), and *competitive* ($ENP \geq 2.5$).⁷ Figure 2 presents the results. In 2015, 28 of 36 assemblies (78%) qualified as one-party dominant, with none reaching the competitive threshold. By 2023, only 15 (42%) remained one-party dominant, 18 (50%) showed moderate competition, and 3 (8%) qualified as competitive. The shift toward greater fragmentation is broad-based, not driven by a few outlier states.

⁶Paired t-test, 2019 vs. 2023: $t = 3.10$, $p = 0.004$; Wilcoxon signed-rank: $W = 105$, $p = 0.002$. The 2015-to-2019 change fails both tests ($p > 0.24$). A Friedman test across all three terms confirms the overall shift ($\chi^2 = 21.7$, $p < 0.001$).

⁷The 1.5 threshold for one-party dominance and the 2.5 threshold for competitive multipartism follow conventional applications of Laakso and Taagepera (1979), in the spirit of Sartori (1976)'s qualitative classifications: an ENP below 1.5 implies that a single party holds a substantial supermajority of seats (a 75/25 split yields $ENP \approx 1.6$, while a 90/10 split yields $ENP \approx 1.22$), and an ENP at or above 2.5 indicates effective multipartism (no single party holds an outright majority of expected vote weight).

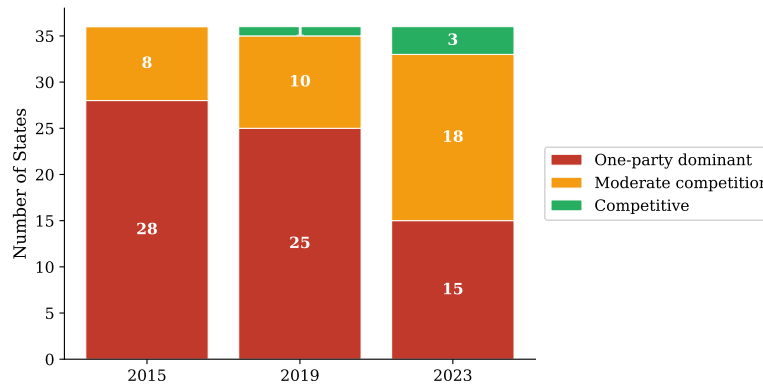


Figure 2: Number of state assemblies by competition type, 2015–2023. One-party dominant assemblies (ENP < 1.5) fell from 28 in 2015 to 15 in 2023, while states with moderate competition rose from 8 to 18.

Zonal means vary descriptively, though a Kruskal-Wallis test finds no significant differences across zones in any single term.⁸

All six zones saw ENP increase by 2023. The South East (1.98) and North East (1.86) led the increases, driven by the Labour Party’s breakthrough and multiparty entry respectively. The South West (1.43) and North West (1.48) remained the least fragmented, consistent with the APC’s deep institutional hold in both regions.

Turnover in Nigerian state assemblies is high. Only 33.3% of legislators in the 2019–2023 term had served in the 2015–2019 term, and 31.8% of 2023–2027 legislators had served previously. This means that roughly two-thirds of all state assembly members are new in each electoral cycle. The correlation between return rates and party dominance is weak: states with higher governor’s party seat shares have marginally higher return rates, and the correlation with ENP is near zero. The combination of high turnover and one-party dominance suggests that governors are not building long-serving loyalist blocs but instead replacing entire assemblies each cycle with fresh cohorts of party members. This is consistent with a model of executive dominance in which individual legislators are interchangeable instruments of party control and not independent political actors.

One demographic feature of the assemblies is worth noting before turning to the

⁸Kruskal-Wallis H-test: $p = 0.65$ (2015), $p = 0.79$ (2019), $p = 0.46$ (2023). The within-zone variance exceeds the between-zone variance.

partisan results. Women’s representation in Nigerian state assemblies remains very low across the period. Women held 22 seats in 2015 (2.2%), 43 in 2019 (4.3%), and 55 in 2023 (5.5%). The geographic distribution is uneven: the South East (10.1%) and South West (8.5%) account for most women legislators, while the North West produced one woman across all three terms. Women are proportionally distributed across parties, indicating that the binding constraint on representation is regional and cultural, not partisan (Yoon, 2004). The descriptive results that follow are conditioned on this low overall level of women’s representation, so I report partisan composition results for the chamber as a whole instead of disaggregating by gender.

5.1 Supermajority Control across the Three Terms

H1 predicts that the governor’s party should hold supermajority control of the assembly ($\geq 67\%$ of seats) in the majority of states in every term. This is the baseline expectation of the executive-dominance account: if governors manufacture legislative majorities through candidate selection, patronage, and cross-carpeting, supermajority control should be the modal outcome, and it should not depend on the conditions of any single electoral cycle. The evidence confirms H1 while showing where the margin has begun to narrow.

The governor’s party held supermajority control ($\geq 67\%$ of seats) in 30 of 36 assemblies in 2015, 28 of 36 in 2019, and 21 of 36 in 2023. The full-period decline is statistically significant, though the individual term-to-term transitions are not.⁹ Even after this decline, the 2023 figure means that the governor commands the two-thirds majority required for constitutional actions in the majority of states. This finding bears directly on H1: supermajority control of the assembly is the modal outcome across all three terms, and even where it fails to hold, it does so by margins that leave the governor’s party as the largest single bloc. The mean governor’s party seat share fell from 83% in 2015 to 79% in 2019 and 71% in 2023; the full-period decline is significant, but

⁹McNemar test on discordant pairs, 2015 vs. 2023: $p = 0.023$; Cochran’s Q across all three terms: $Q = 7.4$, $p = 0.024$. Neither the 2015-to-2019 nor the 2019-to-2023 transition individually reaches significance.

again the action is concentrated in the 2019-to-2023 transition.¹⁰

The largest term-to-term shift concerns the near-elimination of assemblies with *zero* opposition members. Appendix Table A10 lists the states in this category in each term.

Zero-opposition assemblies fell from 10 in 2019 to 1 in 2023, a change that is statistically significant.¹¹ Opposition fragmentation, while not threatening the governor's dominance, ensured that at least some non-governing party members gained seats in nearly every assembly. Borno, where the APC won all 28 seats in both 2019 and 2023, is the only remaining all-one-party assembly.

Appendix Figure A2 shows the state-level dynamics. The 2019–2023 transition saw ENP increase in the large majority of states, driven by the entry of LP, NNPP, and other new or lesser known parties.

5.1.1 Opposition Fragmentation Without Consolidation

The 2023 electoral cycle drove the changes in assembly composition. What made 2023 different was opposition fragmentation. The 2023 presidential election produced three-way competition for the first time in the Fourth Republic. Peter Obi's Labour Party candidacy mobilized voters across the South East, translating into 41 state assembly seats concentrated in Abia (10), Anambra (10), and Enugu (15). Rabiun Kwankwaso's NNPP captured 25 of Kano's 40 assembly seats, the first time since 1999 that any third party dominated any single state assembly. Smaller parties, including the ADC (16 seats), SDP (8), and YPP (8), won scattered seats at the PDP's expense. In total, parties other than the APC and PDP won 119 seats in 2023, up from 67 in 2015 and 40 in 2019.

This fragmentation raised ENP mechanically and eliminated zero-opposition assemblies in all but one state. But it did not threaten gubernatorial dominance because the new opposition parties split the anti-governor vote. The LP won one governorship (Alex Otti in Abia) and the NNPP won one (Abba Yusuf in Kano), but these remain

¹⁰Paired t-test, 2015 vs. 2023: $t = -2.79$, $p = 0.008$; Wilcoxon: $p = 0.004$. The 2015-to-2019 change is not significant ($p = 0.47$); the 2019-to-2023 change reaches significance in the Wilcoxon test ($p = 0.015$) but not the t-test ($p = 0.09$).

¹¹McNemar test: $p = 0.004$ for 2019 vs. 2023; $p = 0.008$ for 2015 vs. 2023. All states that lost zero-opposition status gained at least one opposition seat; none moved in the opposite direction.

isolated footholds: two governorships out of 36 do not provide the patronage infrastructure to sustain legislative loyalty across a majority of states. The PDP, which had been the primary vehicle for opposition, shed seats to multiple competitors simultaneously: its national total fell from 391 to 305 while the APC maintained 564, nearly matching its 2015 figure of 576.

Governor-president alignment shows the same direction. Pooled across terms, the alignment effect is small in unconditional comparisons but becomes precise when state-level controls are added.¹² In 2023 alone, the gap is statistically significant: non-aligned governors face a mean ENP of 1.96 compared to 1.53 for aligned governors, and hold a mean seat share of 0.60 versus 0.78.¹³ This reflects the fact that opposition-governed states in 2023 are precisely those where APC, LP, NNPP, and residual PDP support all compete for seats, producing the highest fragmentation. Figure 3 displays the alignment gap and the 2023 shift in the joint distribution of ENP and governor-party seat share.

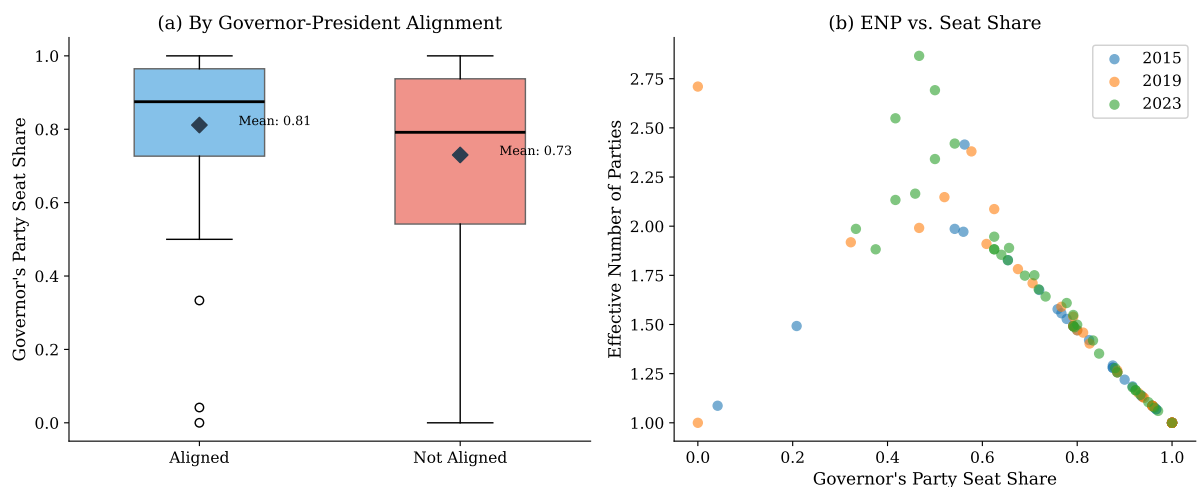


Figure 3: (a) Governor's party seat share by governor-president alignment status. (b) Scatter plot of ENP vs. governor's party seat share across all 108 state-terms, colored by election year. The 2023 observations shift toward higher fragmentation across both aligned and non-aligned states.

Table 1 reports OLS and logistic regressions of partisan competition on state-level

¹²Welch t-test, aligned vs. non-aligned, pooled: $p = 0.17$ for ENP; $p = 0.08$ for seat share. The same comparisons with controls in Table 1, Models 2 and 3, yield $p = 0.057$ and $p = 0.051$ respectively.

¹³Welch t-test, 2023 only: $p = 0.007$ for ENP; $p = 0.004$ for seat share. The difference is absent in 2015 ($p > 0.54$) and 2019 ($p > 0.47$).

covariates. No state-level characteristic, including oil-producing status, gubernatorial term status, state revenue, or geopolitical zone, predicts assembly composition. The 2023 year dummy is the only consistent predictor across all specifications. Governor-president alignment is statistically significant in the supermajority logit (Model 4) and marginally so for ENP and seat share (Models 2 and 3); the alignment effect strengthens when the sample is restricted to the verified 2019–2023 observations (Online Appendix Table A9). State fixed-effects estimates wash out the cross-sectional alignment association, indicating that it reflects between-state differences not within-state change. A first-difference specification confirms that governor party switches raise ENP and is statistically significant (Appendix Table A5, Model 6), motivating the quasi-experimental analysis below.

Table 1: Determinants of Partisan Competition in State Assemblies (N=108)

	Model 1 ENP (OLS)	Model 2 ENP (OLS)	Model 3 Seat Share (OLS)	Model 4 Supermaj. (Logit)
Gov-Pres Aligned		−0.169 (0.092)	0.092 (0.048)	1.327* (0.572)
Oil-producing	0.152 (0.221)	0.196 (0.235)	−0.122 (0.098)	−0.347 (0.934)
2nd-term Governor	−0.088 (0.079)	−0.090 (0.078)	0.044 (0.040)	0.340 (0.498)
Log IGR		0.018 (0.062)	−0.011 (0.026)	0.074 (0.378)
Year 2019	0.103 (0.083)	0.080 (0.080)	−0.031 (0.052)	−0.332 (0.644)
Year 2023	0.400*** (0.088)	0.381*** (0.092)	−0.110* (0.044)	−1.395* (0.633)
Zone dummies	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
R^2 / Pseudo R^2	0.208	0.231	0.144	0.139
N	108	108	108	108

Clustered SEs by state in parentheses (Models 1–3). * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. State fixed-effects, first-difference, and verified-subsample specifications are reported in the online appendix.

5.2 The Governor Party-Switch Quasi-Experiment

I argue that party turnover in the governorship, not the assembly’s own composition, drives the observed rise in fragmentation. Separating the two is difficult in cross-section, because a governor’s party and the assembly’s composition are jointly produced by the same electoral forces. The between-term governor party-switches pro-

vide the variation needed to analyze this issue. Seven such switches occurred across the three cycles, providing a natural experiment.¹⁴ In each, the party holding the governorship changed from one term to the next, and the incoming governor inherited an assembly built by the previous party's machinery.

The identifying logic rests on the sequence of decisions. Legislators are nominated through party primaries and select their party affiliation before any votes are cast; neither returning members nor newly elected ones can know the gubernatorial outcome in advance, and none chooses a party in anticipation of which party will win the governorship. The assembly that a new governor inherits is therefore a fixed roster, recruited under the previous governor's party machine, whose partisan composition was settled independently of the gubernatorial result. The incoming governor's party identity is in this sense exogenous to the assembly's existing composition, which rules out the reverse-causation explanation in which the assembly's makeup determines the governor's party. The legislative outcomes that the assembly carries into the following cycle can be taken as its response to the arrival of a governor from a different party: a rise in the effective number of parties and a fall in the governor-party seat share are attributable to the party turnover and not to any prior feature of the chamber. Only seven cases qualify for analysis here, and the switches are not randomly assigned across states. I therefore treat the quasi-experiment as one part of the evidence, taken alongside the cross-carpeting one discussed in the next section. When a governorship changes party between terms, what happens to the assembly?

Table 2 compares ENP and governor's party seat share before and after party switches, contrasting switch states with non-switch states.

¹⁴An eighth party-switch state-term appears in the data (Sokoto's 2014 PDP-to-APC switch) but is not analyzable in the between-term framework because it occurred mid-2015–2019 term.

Table 2: ENP and Governor's Party Seat Share Before and After Governor Party Switches

	2015 → 2019		2019 → 2023	
	Switch (N=4)	No Switch (N=32)	Switch (N=3)	No Switch (N=33)
<i>Mean ENP</i>				
Before	1.359	1.286	1.470	1.384
After	1.823	1.337	1.532	1.153
Δ	+0.464	+0.051	+0.062	-0.231
<i>Mean Gov Party Seat Share</i>				
Before	0.847	0.833	0.808	0.794
After	0.308	0.856	0.242	0.608
Δ	-0.539	+0.023	-0.566	-0.186

The result is consistent with H2 (assembly lag). In the 2015–2019 transition, the four states where the governorship changed party saw ENP rise and the new governor's party seat share fall, while non-switch states barely changed. The same direction holds in the 2019–2023 transition. Every one of the seven party-switch state-terms moves in the predicted direction (ENP up, governor-party seat share down).¹⁵ The small number of switch states (four and three) limits power, but the delta-seat-share decline is significant for the first transition.¹⁶ The individual cases show the same direction: in Imo, where the governorship switched from PDP to APC in 2019, the new governor faced an assembly populated by his predecessor's PDP allies. In Zamfara, where the governorship switched from APC to PDP in 2023, the new PDP governor inherited an APC-dominated assembly. Online Appendix Table A6 reports each party-switch state-term with ENP and gov-party seat share before and after the switch.

These results support H2 and the interpretation that assemblies are products of the *previous* governor's party machinery. A new governor from a different party inherits an assembly populated by his predecessor's loyalists and must wait until the next election cycle, or rely on cross-carpeting, to reshape the legislature. The two strategies are not chosen against each other but are pursued in sequence: cross-carpeting begins almost immediately and continues as long as resistance allows, while candidate re-

¹⁵Sign test against random direction: $p = (1/2)^7 = 0.008$, two-sided $p = 0.016$.

¹⁶Mann-Whitney test on delta-seat-share, 2015–2019 transition: $U = 18$, $p = 0.02$. Delta-ENP tests: $p > 0.20$ in both transitions. The first-difference regression (Online Appendix Table A5, Model 6) provides a higher-powered test, estimating a 0.49-point increase in ENP for party-switch states ($p < 0.05$).

placement waits on the primary calendar of the next cycle. Imo in 2019 and Zamfara in 2023 show the same compressed sequence. Each governor first absorbed willing defectors and then used party primaries at the following election to install loyalists in the remaining seats.

5.3 Cross-Carpeting: The Defection Mechanism

The results show that state-level characteristics explain little of the variation in assembly dominance. I now turn to the micro-level mechanism that the data can illuminate directly: cross-carpeting, the practice of legislators switching parties between or during terms. If elite defection sustains one-party dominance, we should observe asymmetric switching toward the ruling party (H3).

I track the party affiliations of legislators who served in multiple terms. The fuzzy-matching procedure described in Section 4.1 identifies 637 returning members across the three cycles. After reconciling constituency labels rendered inconsistently across the underlying data sources, 633 of these are matched to their previous-term record by state and constituency; the four unmatched cases are legislators who moved to a different constituency between terms, for whom no same-constituency match exists. Of the 633 matched returnees, 117 (18.5%) switched parties between terms (Appendix Table A11). Online Appendix Table A7 reports the full party-of-origin by party-of-destination transition matrix.¹⁷

Figure 4 visualises these transitions. The direction of switching is overwhelmingly toward the APC. Of the 117 party switches, 41 were PDP → APC.

¹⁷The matrix totals 632 because one switcher in the 2019–2023 to 2023–2027 transition has missing party data on one side and is excluded from the cell counts.

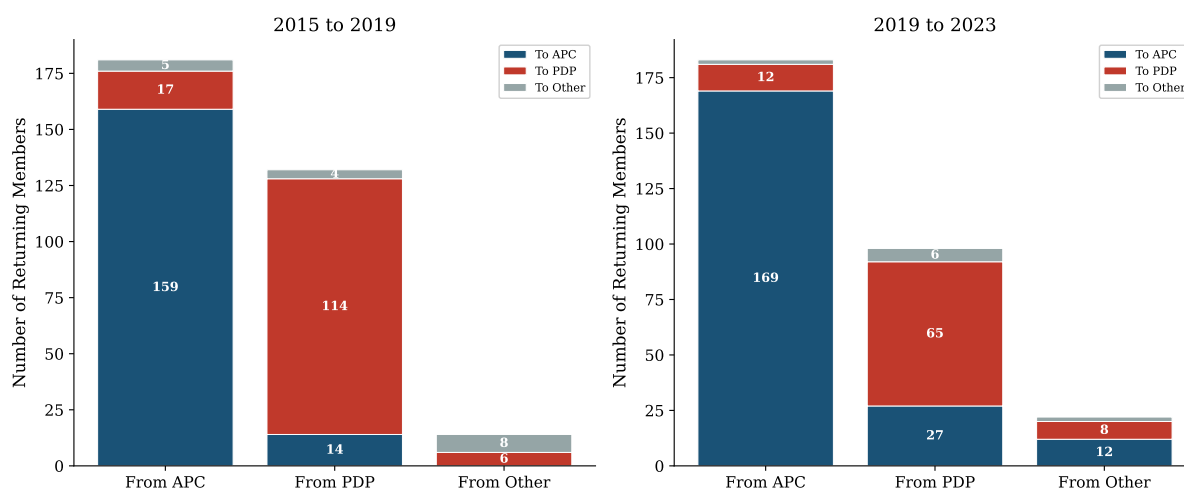


Figure 4: Party transitions among returning state assembly members. Each bar shows the original party of returning members; segments indicate the party they joined in the subsequent term. PDP → APC defection accounts for the largest single flow in both transitions.

The asymmetry is consistent with H3. Coding switches relative to the governor's party in each state: in the 2015–2019 to 2019–2023 transition, 57% of classifiable party-switchers moved *toward* the governor's party while 35% moved away. In the 2019–2023 to 2023–2027 transition, 63% moved toward the governor's party and 24% away. A binomial test rejects the null of symmetric switching: pooled across both transitions, 71 of 104 classifiable switches moved toward the governor's party.¹⁸ The direction of switching is bandwagoning toward executive power.

The APC-level flow tells a complementary story. In the 2023 transition alone, 40 returning legislators crossed into the APC while 16 left it, a net flow of +24 in a single inter-electoral period. Returning legislators converged on the federal incumbent's party even as the APC's overall national seat total moved by 7 seats across the eight years from 2015 to 2023 (576 to 564). The 2023 transition also saw new directions of switching: 5 PDP members moved to the NNPP (reflecting the Kwankwaso movement in Kano), and several moved to LP and other new parties, consistent with the broader fragmentation trend.

The governor's party attracts defectors whether or not it matches the president's

¹⁸Binomial test against 50/50 null, one-sided: $p < 0.001$ pooled; $p = 0.0002$ for the 2023 transition alone. The 2019 transition falls just short ($p = 0.08$), consistent with the smaller sample of classifiable switches.

party. In opposition-governed states, returning legislators still gravitate toward the governor's party, suggesting that state-level executive power (control over patronage, committee assignments, and legislative resources) is the proximate driver of cross-carpeting, with federal alignment reinforcing the effect.

Ebonyi State Governor Dave Umahi governed as a PDP member from 2015 and presided over an all-PDP assembly: 24 of 24 seats in both the 2015 and 2019 terms. In November 2020, Umahi defected to the APC, citing the party's treatment of the South East. By 2023, the APC held 19 of 24 seats, with 3 remaining PDP. Of the seven legislators who returned from the previous term, six switched from PDP to APC. The remaining seats turned over to new APC members recruited through the governor's now-APC party machinery. The Speaker whom Umahi had installed, Francis Nwifuru, also crossed to the APC and rode the defection wave to win the 2023 gubernatorial election itself. Ebonyi condenses the full logic of one-party consolidation into a single case: the governor switches party, returning legislators follow, new recruits fill the remaining seats through the governor's control of party primaries, and the speakership serves as a stepping stone, not an independent power base.

Cross-carpeting alone cannot account for the APC's seat recovery between 2019 and 2023. The APC gained 31 seats (from 533 to 564), of which only a fraction can be attributed to returning PDP defectors. The remainder reflects the replacement of retiring or defeated PDP legislators with new APC members, suggesting that one-party dominance operates through two complementary channels: elite defection among returning legislators and the party's ability to dominate new candidate recruitment. The cross-carpeting data capture only the first channel; the second operates through the governor's control over party primaries and candidate selection, which is difficult to observe directly but which the 67–69% turnover rate makes visible: governors repopulate assemblies with fresh co-partisans each cycle.¹⁹

¹⁹Robustness checks shown in the Online Appendix Tables A8 and A9 confirm these results. Restricting to verified 2019–2023 data (N=72), excluding off-cycle states, and substituting HHI for ENP all produce consistent estimates. The verified-subsample re-estimation strengthens the alignment coefficient across all three dependent variables and leaves the null findings for oil, term status, and IGR unchanged. Separate regressions by year confirm that the alignment association is concentrated in 2023 and absent in earlier terms, consistent with the opposition fragmentation interpretation.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

This paper contributes to literature by identifying a condition under which rising party-system fragmentation does not deliver competition or accountability, and shows that under that condition fragmentation works as a mechanism of authoritarian resilience. The democratization literature ordinarily interprets more parties as more competition and more competition as more accountability. Nigeria's state assemblies shows the opposite. The two headline trends move in opposite directions: fragmentation increased and zero-opposition assemblies fell from ten to one, while the governor's party retained supermajority control in 21 of 36 states. The system moved from two-party dominance toward multiparty dominance with a fragmented opposition, a form that reduces the visibility of one-party rule without enhancing legislative independence. Where the entering parties individually lack the patronage infrastructure to cohere, splitting the anti-incumbent vote among them raises the effective number of parties and refills opposition benches while leaving the governor's party as the only disciplined bloc on the floor. The count of parties rises; the capacity to check the executive does not.

This modifies the multipartism-implies-competition argument. Across countries, fragmentation does little to democratic quality on average (Valentim and Dinas, 2024); the Nigerian case identifies a condition under which fragmentation weakens accountability. The argument holds when an entering opposition can consolidate; it fails, and can reverse, when the opposition arrives too resource-poor to do so. That condition is generalizable to other subnational authoritarian setting in which the incumbent controls the patronage that sustains legislative cohesion, and in which opposition support scatters across parties that cannot, should exhibit the same divergence between apparent pluralism and actual accountability. Subnational democratic erosion is routinely tracked with fragmentation and competition indices; the Nigerian case shows those indices moving toward pluralism precisely as executive capture holds firm, so counting parties can register health where the substance is capture. Detecting subnational erosion requires attention to whether opposition seats translate into a bloc that can act,

not to how many parties hold them.

What emerges is democratic unevenness: competitive dynamics at the center co-exist with, and fuel, one-party dominance at the periphery. National democratization can empower the party that wins at the center to consolidate control over subnational institutions (Gibson, 2005, 2012). The same dynamic has parallels across diverse federal systems, from the American “Solid South” (Key, 1949; Mickey, 2015) to Argentine provincial rentierism (Gervasoni, 2010) and post-transition Mexico (Giraudy, 2015). Nigeria provides the African case that confirms, extends, and modifies this theory: the entry of new opposition parties can fragment the anti-governor vote without producing the concentrated legislative opposition needed for accountability (Snyder, 2001; Giraudy et al., 2019).

The 2015-to-2019 transition produced no significant change in any measure of assembly composition. The 2019-to-2023 transition shifted three measures at once: ENP rose, supermajority control fell, and zero-opposition assemblies fell as well. The shift came from opposition fragmentation, not from weakening gubernatorial control. The LP and NNPP won seats in their regional strongholds but took only one governorship each at the 2023 elections (Abia and Kano), too few to build the patronage infrastructure needed to retain legislative loyalty at scale. The PDP fragmented after the Atiku-Wike split and the revolt of the G5, a group of five dissident PDP governors (Wike of Rivers, Ortom of Benue, Makinde of Oyo, Ugwuanyi of Enugu, and Ikpeazu of Abia) who refused to campaign for Atiku in 2023 and subsequently drifted toward the APC. The APC’s national seat total moved by 7 seats across the period: 576 in 2015, 564 in 2023. Though more parties won seats, the governor’s party still controls the assembly floor.

No observable state characteristic predicts the variation in the results. Oil-producing status, gubernatorial term status, state revenue, geopolitical zone, and off-cycle election timing all show no association with assembly composition. The mechanisms of dominance operate below the level that state-term regressions can capture. The cross-carpeting and party-switch analyses provide more direct evidence. Elite bandwag-

oning toward the governor's party is statistically significant at conventional levels: nearly one in five returning legislators switched parties, and the direction of switching favored the governor's party at rates above chance. The governor's control over patronage and committee assignments rewards loyalty (Heller and Mershon, 2009; Mershon and Shvetsova, 2013); FPTP electoral rules in small assemblies (24–40 seats) amplify shifts in party support; and the governor's influence over party primaries allows incumbents to control candidate selection. The party-switch quasi-experiment confirms the flip side: when a new governor arrives from a different party, the assembly remains populated by the predecessor's allies. The combination of asymmetric defection and high turnover (two-thirds new members each cycle) suggests that dominance reproduces itself through both the conversion of returning legislators and the recruitment of fresh co-partisans.

Gubernatorial defections to the APC accelerated after the 2023 elections. Between April and December 2025, eight PDP governors crossed to the APC: Sheriff Oborevwori (Delta) in April, Umo Eno (Akwa Ibom) in June, Peter Mbah (Enugu) in October, Douye Diri (Bayelsa) in November, and Siminalayi Fubara (Rivers) in December, alongside Agbu Kefas (Taraba), Ahmadu Fintiri (Adamawa), and Caleb Mutfwang (Plateau) over the same period (The Nation, 2025; Vanguard, 2026). Abba Yusuf of Kano crossed from the NNPP. The APC also took Edo from the PDP at the September 2024 off-cycle gubernatorial election, with Monday Okpebholo defeating PDP's Asue Ighodalo (Vanguard, 2024). The APC controlled 31 of 36 governorships by January 2026, up from 21 after the 2023 elections. Defecting governors brought legislative allies with them, as Rivers showed in December 2023 when 27 of 32 lawmakers defected with Speaker Amaewhule. The cross-carpeting mechanism documented in this paper predicts that the 2027 state assembly elections will produce larger APC majorities in these newly aligned states.

The PDP's fragmentation, already visible in the 2023 data, has deepened. The party's internal crisis began with the dispute between Atiku Abubakar and Rivers governor Nyesom Wike over the 2023 vice-presidential nomination. The G5 revolt

followed; the data capture the assembly-level consequences as states governed by G5 members saw opposition fragmentation in 2023 as PDP cohesion collapsed. The Labour Party's gains in the South East, mobilising voters around Peter Obi's candidacy, have not translated into a durable opposition presence in state assemblies; LP holds only the Abia governorship and lacks the patronage infrastructure to retain legislative loyalty across multiple states. These developments suggest that the 2023 data captures the early stages of a broader realignment rather than a stable equilibrium. If the cross-carpeting dynamics documented here continue, the 2027 assemblies may see a return to APC seat shares closer to the 2015 figure of 576 of 991, with fewer opposition parties capable of mounting sustained challenges.

The opposition's inability to cohere is not confined to the state assemblies, and it has reproduced itself at the national level ahead of the 2027 general elections. In 2025 the leading opposition figures tried to reverse the fragmentation this paper documents. Atiku Abubakar, former Senate President David Mark, and former Kaduna governor Nasir El-Rufai assembled a coalition that adopted the African Democratic Congress (ADC) as a common platform in July 2025, and Peter Obi left the Labour Party to join it in December 2025 (Premium Times, 2026). The attempt collapsed within a year. After the coalition's principals deadlocked over the presidential ticket, Obi and Rabiu Kwankwaso abandoned the ADC and took up membership of the Nigerian Democratic Congress (NDC) in May 2026, leaving Atiku on the ADC and dividing the anti-incumbent bloc into at least three vehicles (Daily Post, 2026; The Guardian, 2026). The dynamic this paper traces inside the assemblies, an opposition that multiplies parties faster than it can consolidate them, now governs the contest for the presidency itself. If this scattering holds into 2027, the anti-APC vote will divide across the ADC, the NDC, a diminished Labour Party, and a PDP hollowed out by gubernatorial defection, reproducing at national scale the vote-splitting that this paper shows sustains gubernatorial supermajorities. The mechanism predicts that opposition fragmentation will again register as a rising effective number of parties in the 2027 state assemblies while leaving the APC as the largest and most disciplined bloc in most chambers, so

that the count of parties climbs even as the capacity to check the executive does not.

The constitutional design of Nigeria's state assemblies assumes a degree of legislative independence that the data show is unavailable under one-party dominance. The two-thirds majority required for gubernatorial impeachment (Section 188) cannot be reached when the governor's party holds the majority of seats, since the governor's allies can block any accountability measure. One-party dominance also compromises budget oversight, legislative investigations, and the confirmation of executive appointments, since the governor's co-partisans control the assembly floor.

These findings have direct implications for the parliamentary strengthening programs that international and domestic organizations have pursued in Nigeria. Organizations such as the Policy and Legal Advocacy Centre (PLAC), the National Democratic Institute (NDI), and programs funded by the UK's Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) have invested in building legislative capacity at the state level: training committee chairs, supporting public hearings, and improving budget analysis. This paper's findings suggest that such programs face a structural constraint that capacity-building alone cannot overcome. When the governor's party holds 71 percent of seats and individual legislators are replaceable (with two-thirds turnover each cycle), the incentive structure for legislative independence is absent regardless of legislators' technical capacity. Effective reform would need to address the upstream causes of one-party dominance: the governor's control over party primaries, the patronage flows that incentivise cross-carpeting, and the FPTP electoral rules that translate vote leads of any size into seat supermajorities.

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